Love Passes Beyond the Incredible Hawk of Innocence

By Diane Wakoski

Innocence is suffering

and the loss of that innocence is something to fear . . .

INTRODUCTION

It has been said that as long as people suffer, there will be poetry; that part of what a poem does is try to make sense of the experience -- to find meaning in the suffering.

Poet Diane Wakoski summed up the process of writing poetry: "First comes the story. Then comes the reaction to the story. Then comes the telling and retelling of the story."

In this autobiographical poem, Wakoski tells the tale of how innocence is lost in an abusive relationship. Love Passes Beyond the Incredible Hawk of Innocence is dedicated to her first husband S. Shepard Sherbell.

(Pg 97-103) The stairs will forget your footsteps;
the rain will wash away all the invisible
spots where you've stood;
my hair will not curl in the places
you've touched it;
& newspapers will be printed each day

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mentioning neither of our names.

I had passed through the spinal doors
of 2 hospitals,
breathing ether
and passing clots of blood like
soft-backed
red-black
beetles,
each as large as a thumb.

I had eaten the bones of children
and washed dishes for the world.
I had lived in jails,
the bars made of clocks striking 9 to 6
with overtime on Saturdays;
prison jobs stacking paper over my head
filled with complaints,
irritating as a dog locked up in a room and
constantly
barking,
each piece of paper/thousands a day /
had to be individually smiled to

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till the weight fell down at night
and the smiles crumbled like dry crusts of bread.
I had stood up to the insults of
national enemies.
junior high school principals
and assistant principals
who lived their lives by 24 lesson plans a week
aim
motivation
pivotal questions
procedures
summaries
and retarded my own heartbeats with the
frustration
of retarded readers.

I had fallen in love with the sharp edges of razor blades
that will cut the flesh of your arms so fast you don't feel
any pain.
I had signed my name in blood
in a thousand registers
and found that people laughed at my penmanship,
or criticized its execution.

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I had spent years in alchemical experiments,
and only singed my hands
until they looked like a winter poplar at dusk.

But it was not until I met you,
my husband for two short years,
whose love was like the full moon on a night of total
eclipse,
whose mind was like a flash flood,
whose eyes were like the sound of coyotes in the
Southern
California
hills 20 years ago,
whose words were a fire escape in a burning building,
whose boldness lifted me as a hawk would a snake
before he flings it
down on the ground
to bash the life out of it,
whose madness captured me
in the collapsing tunnel of my own defenses;
that world that had bled me,
jailed me,
starved me,

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laughed at me,

rejected me,

was one I could feel

at last

getting at me,

as you might feel the

hot smokey air from

a burning room creeping under the door crack

in the room where you've been defending yourself;

it was not until I met you

that the door broke down

-- or I opened it --

and my innocence was consumed,

burned away.

Those of you who are listening to me now,

some walk leaving your prints in snow,

or soot from burning buildings,

some in jade from the stylized places you travel,

or ink that you've spilled in keeping accounts,

you know, I cannot doubt,

how indefinable the borders of countries are,

how easy to walk and find yourself having been in two

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countries or

two states, sometimes one foot in one,

the other foot in another,.

You know how the worst ravages of childhood

in some ways never touch you,

while a feather or a leaf falling by chance as you walk on

the street

at a later time, may bruise you

break your arm,

or destroy your life.

When we are innocent,

we know nothing about innocence,

live everything the hard way.

And it protects us.

It seemed to me as if I had been through all the possible

terrors; and meeting this one man

would relieve them all.

But that leaf, that feather,

something

must have pushed down my door.

No longer did the crystal pane surround me.

No longer could it protect me.

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No longer could I walk in those same
impossible places
without realizing
their danger.

And that is the secret
-- if the word could be used to mean
reason
formula
explanation
of why I can't have you
in my life
anymore,
why I can't dream of you like a sunset
wringing out over the hills & a face
reds, golds
purples,
why I can't even desire you
or credit you with the magnificent passion you have.

You hurt me.
You locked me in a room and took away my glasses when
you found me

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reading a book by a man you hated;
you pounded my head against the floor when I wouldn't
change my name;
you tried to lock me away in a mental institution when I
wanted to
go to a writers' conference for two weeks,
you called up my old friends and said you'd castrate them
if
they
talked to me;
you hit me in the mouth every time I disagreed with you;
you would not let me answer the phone or open my own
mail;
you threw out poems & letters that were from or about
other men;
you created enormous debts and ridiculed me for
worrying
about them;
you made me feel guilty about everything in a way even
an
evil parent
could not have been able;

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you hurt me,
and each time I wondered,
“What have I done wrong this time?”
And as long as I retained my innocence,
I believed I needed you,
felt I wanted you,
could not,
would not,
terminate the madness;
it was you,
in fact,
who had to do that,
sent me away
& knew it was final.

I have reached the age of 30.
but feel each moment of my life
has been clawed out
as if I were making a hole around
myself,
in which I could breathe.
Every freedom paid for once & again.
But suffering protects people.

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Keeps them involved in the situation at hand.
Does not allow the mind to wander
or become cynical.

Innocence is suffering,
and the loss of that innocence is something to fear.
But the poem can take its place
in this world.

Jewels dropped on the stairs
or growing on bushes & trees
remind me of your unreality.
The ivory-braceleted hand
picking up a pomegranate
which when opened
gleams,
with its rows of translucent seeds,
ready to be transplanted,
as a new kind of heart.
This could be my different life.
the faces on letters which bite at my
fingers
when I tear the paper

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and read out words, hard as green
walnuts,
that would stain my fingers if I could
touch them
are your voice
which left such stains, long & streaked
across
my face.
The lesson of innocence:
that love is not inevitable
but must, like other good things
be chosen
to make any sense.

Not only the stairs
but my ears, muffling as soft towels,
will forget your footsteps.
The only traces rain will not wash away
are the jade prints left in Chinese poems.

Old hair falls out of old follicles
and more grows in.
The newspaper is not the poem

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of our time.
Remember the walls of hospitals.
Every flower is a diary.
A mountain is a history; our bones
may constitute,
if we're lucky,
an interesting story.
Love passes over innocence,
beyond the incredible hawks which is the world
ready to tear us apart,
teaches us the meaning of something
once it is past.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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